Johan Ahlbäck

Doctor of Philosophy in Political Science

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Nationality: Finnish

CURRENT POSITIONS

Social Science Research Fellow 2025–present
Stanford University, School of Medicine, Department of Medicine (Primary Care and Population Health)
Member of the Geldsetzer Lab. I examine off-target effects of vaccination campaigns, with a focus on dementia, and run causal analyses of large electronic health records using regression discontinuity, difference-in-differences and matching designs.

Visiting Fellow 2025–present
London School of Economics and Political Science, Department of Methodology

EDUCATION

PhD in Political Science 2020
London School of Economics and Political Science, Department of Government
Dissertation: *Electoral Integrity in Unconsolidated Democracies: Challenges and Potential Remedies*

Master of European Affairs 2010
Lund University, Faculty of Social Sciences
Politics and Governance of the European Union; thesis on EU policies on irregular immigration (with Distinction)

Master of Social Sciences (incl. Bachelor of Social Sciences) 2008
University of Helsinki, Faculty of Social Sciences (partly at Åbo Akademi University)
Major: World Politics; Minor: History. Thesis: *News Media and Voter Turnout* (Eximia Cum Laude Approbatur)

PUBLICATIONS

Ahlbäck, Johan and Alex Yeandle. 2026. "Projecting Politics: How Voters Infer Community Support in Low-Information Environments." *European Journal of Political Research*. doi: 10.1017/S1475676526101406

Ahlbäck, Johan and Ryan Jablonski. 2025. "How to Distinguish Human Error from Election Fraud: Evidence from the 2019 Malawi Election." *British Journal of Political Science* 55. doi: 10.1017/S0007123425100951

Seim, Brigitte, Ryan Jablonski and Johan Ahlbäck. 2020. "How Information about Foreign Aid Affects Public Spending Decisions: Evidence from a Field Experiment in Malawi." *Journal of Development Economics* 146: 102522. doi: 10.1016/j.jdeveco.2020.102522

WORK IN PROGRESS

"What Drives Public Trust in Elections? Experimental Evidence from Malawi" (with Alex Yeandle). Preprint.

"Foreign Aid Is Neither a Curse nor a Blessing: Explaining the Effect of Foreign Aid on Voting Behaviour and Accountability" (with Ryan Jablonski and Brigitte Seim).

"Natural Disasters and Electoral Politics in Low-Income States" (with Alex Yeandle).

"Temporal Updating of Retrospective Election Integrity Evaluations" (with Alex Yeandle).

PREVIOUS ACADEMIC POSITIONS

Post-doctoral Fellow in Research Methods 2022–2025
London School of Economics and Political Science, Department of Methodology
Delivered postgraduate lectures and small-group teaching in research design and research methods. Responsibilities included teaching, marking, supervision of graduate dissertations, and administrative duties.

Post-doctoral Fellow in International Development Management 2021–2022
London School of Economics and Political Science, Department of International Development

Delivered postgraduate small-group teaching for a cohort in international development management. Responsibilities included teaching, marking, mentoring, supervision of graduate dissertations, and administrative duties.

Teaching Fellow in Politics and Research Methods 2019–2021
Royal Holloway, University of London, Department of Politics and International Relations

Convened undergraduate modules in politics, international relations and research design. Responsibilities included designing new curricula and course materials, lecturing, seminar teaching both in person and online, setting assessments and marking, supervising undergraduate dissertations, pastoral care, and administrative duties.

Graduate Teaching Assistant 2015–2016
London School of Economics and Political Science

Seminar teaching in politics and quantitative analysis.

RESEARCH GRANTS AND PROJECTS

Building Voter Confidence in Election Results 2024
Principal Investigator — LSE RISF (£20,000)

Designed the project interventions and survey experiment on voter confidence in Malawi; oversaw implementation remotely and in the field; trained enumerators; analysed and reported results.

Strategies of Election Fraud across the Electoral Cycle 2018–2021
Co-Principal Investigator — STICERD (£5,000)

Small-scale field experiment on electoral fraud. Responsible for project planning, research design, liaison with project partners, data analysis and project reports.

Identifying and Preventing Drug Theft in Malawi 2019
Research Support and Analysis — LSE and Department for International Development (DFID)

Project management in Malawi, training of survey research assistants, oversight of project budget and transactions, and data preparation and analysis.

Spatial Inequalities in African Political Economy 2018
Research Support and Analysis — Economic and Social Research Council (ESRC)

Collected and organised sub-national data on economic and development indicators for several Sub-Saharan African countries.

Foreign Aid Allocation in Malawi 2016–2017
Field Research Manager — LSE and AidData (£80,000)

Managed and trained research assistants in Malawi; survey design and data collection; oversaw experimental treatments; project budgeting and transactions; data preparation and analysis.

TEACHING

Applied Regression Analysis (PG) — LSE Methodology; co-convener, lectures and seminars 2023–2025
Fundamentals of Research Design (PG) — LSE Methodology; seminars 2022–2024
Fundamentals of Research Design for International Development (PG) — LSE Methodology; seminars 2022–2023
International Development Management (PG) — LSE International Development; seminars 2021–2022
Voting and Elections in Developing Democracies (UG) — LSE Government; guest lecturer 2021
Introduction to Comparative Politics (UG) — Royal Holloway; co-convener, lectures and seminars 2019–2021
Research Methods in Politics and IR (UG) — Royal Holloway; co-convener, lectures and seminars 2019–2021
Researching Politics and IR: Analysis and Practice (UG) — Royal Holloway; co-convener, lectures and seminars 2019–2021
Advanced Quantitative Methods (PG) — Royal Holloway; seminars 2019–2021
Introduction to Quantitative Analysis (PG) — LSE Methodology; seminars 2016–2017
Democracy and Democratization (UG) — LSE Government; seminars 2015–2016
Intermediate Quantitative Analysis (PG) — LSE Methodology; seminars 2015–2016

SUPERVISION

Master's dissertations, LSE International Development and Methodology (up to three per year) 2021–2025
Undergraduate dissertations, Royal Holloway (up to five per year) 2019–2021

AWARDS

Excellence in Education Award, LSE Department of Methodology 2024
Excellence in Education Award, LSE Department of Methodology 2023
Class Teacher Award, LSE Department of Methodology 2016

PRESENTATIONS AND SERVICE

Conference presentations: APSA Annual Meeting (2020, 2024); EPSA Annual Conference (2024); Politics in the Global South (2024) 2020–2024
Peer review: *Comparative Political Studies*; *British Journal of Political Science*; *Electoral Studies* 2023–2025
LSE public lecture: "Fraud at the Polls: Can Journalists and Statisticians Check? (Mozambique)" 2016

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE OUTSIDE ACADEMIA

UNV Climate Change Research Assistant, International Labour Organization (ILO), Beirut, Lebanon 2010–2012
UNV Project Management Specialist, Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO), Bishkek, Kyrgyz Republic 2009–2010
Technical Officer, EU Central Baltic INTERREG Programme, Mariehamn, Finland 2008–2009
Junior EU Expert, Helsinki Regional Representation to the European Union, Brussels, Belgium 2005–2006

SKILLS AND LANGUAGES

Statistics: R, Stata **GIS:** ArcGIS, QGIS **Survey tools:** Qualtrics, ODK, SurveyCTO
Languages: Swedish (native), English (professional), Finnish (professional), Spanish (beginner)
Military service: Nyland Brigade, Finnish Defence Forces (Medical Sergeant)

Last updated: October 2026